

Early Elizabethan England, 1558–1588

KEY TOPIC 1: QUEEN, GOVERNMENT & RELIGION, 1558–1569

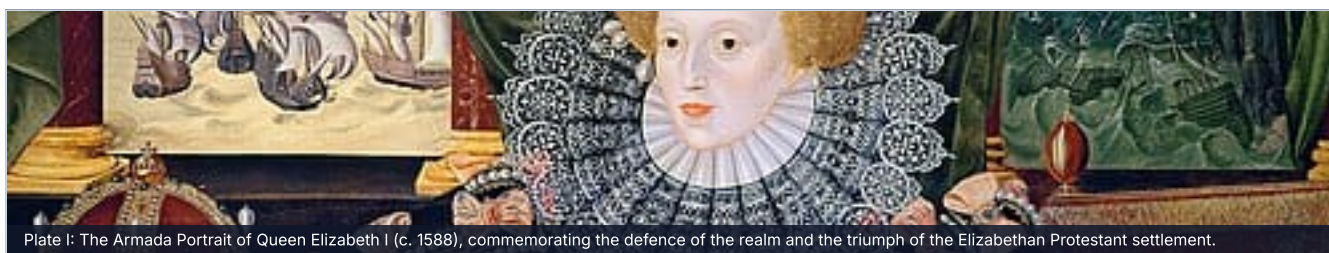


Plate I: The Armada Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I (c. 1588), commemorating the defence of the realm and the triumph of the Elizabethan Protestant settlement.

OVERARCHING ENQUIRY QUESTION

"How did an inexperienced, contested queen establish her royal authority, construct a religious compromise, and secure an isolated England between 1558 and 1569?"

ENQUIRY UNIT	CORE SPECIFICATION THEMES	EXAM SKILL FOCUS
KT 1.1: Accession (1558)	Social structure (Great Chain of Being), Court, Privy Council, gender prejudice, £300,000 Crown debt, and French threat.	Q1 Features • Q2 Causation
KT 1.2: Settlement (1559)	The 'Middle Way': Act of Supremacy (Supreme Governor), Act of Uniformity, Prayer Book, visitations, and Church courts.	Q2 Causation (Why Middle Way?)
KT 1.3: Challenges	Crucifix & Vestment controversies, recusancy, Douai seminaries, and the 1570 Papal Bull (*Regnans in Excelsis*).	Q2 Explain Why • Q3 Essay
KT 1.4: Mary Stuart	Mary, Queen of Scots' claim, Scottish crisis, Workington landing, Casket Letters at York, and English captivity.	Q1 Features • Q3 Evaluative Essay

The Situation on Elizabeth's Accession, 1558

Key Enquiry: From crippling debt to looming foreign invasion: How did an inexperienced queen secure a divided and vulnerable England in 1558? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Governance & Archival Evidence

SECTION 1 SOCIAL HIERARCHY & THE STRUCTURE OF TUDOR GOVERNMENT

[1.1] When Elizabeth Tudor ascended the throne on 17 November 1558 at the age of twenty-five, she inherited a deeply fractured nation of roughly three million people. Tudor society was strictly ordered by the **Great Chain of Being**—an immutable cosmic hierarchy ordained by God in which every individual held a fixed rank and owed total obedience to their social superiors. In the countryside, where 90 per cent of the population lived, the social pyramid was crowned by the nobility (roughly fifty peerage families who owned vast estates) and the gentry (wealthy landowners who dominated county society). Beneath them sat yeomen (independent farmers owning their land), tenant farmers, and at the broad base, landless labourers who scraped a subsistence living. In the burgeoning towns, wealthy merchants formed an urban aristocracy, followed by skilled craftsmen, professionals, and unskilled labourers.

[1.2] Government centred entirely upon the personal authority of the monarch, who claimed to rule by **Divine Right**. Crucially, the Crown possessed no standing army and no salaried national police force, meaning the monarch governed through a web of aristocratic consent and **royal patronage**. By granting land, hereditary titles, lucrative offices, and trading monopolies, Elizabeth bound powerful nobles to her service. Day-to-day governance was directed by the **Privy Council**, a select cadre of approximately nineteen trusted aristocratic advisers who met multiple times weekly to oversee state finance, foreign diplomacy, and the enforcement of law. At its head stood **Sir William Cecil**, whom Elizabeth appointed Principal Secretary on her accession day, establishing a thirty-year political partnership based on moderation, administrative vigilance, and unwavering Protestant loyalty.

[1.3] National legislation and extraordinary finance required the consent of **Parliament**, comprising the House of Lords (hereditary peers and bishops) and the House of Commons (wealthy gentry and burgesses). Unlike modern democracy, Parliament met only when summoned by the Queen—gathering only nine times across her forty-five-year reign, primarily to grant **subsidies** (emergency taxes). In the counties, the monarch's will was enacted by **Lord Lieutenants**, wealthy nobles appointed to raise county militias in wartime, and unpaid **Justices of the Peace (JPs)**. These voluntary magistrates enforced statutory law, inspected highways, collected local rates, and punished petty crime, providing the essential bridge between Whitehall directives and provincial reality.

HISTORICAL SOURCE SIXTEENTH-CENTURY ENGRAVING

c. 1580s

Source A: The Queen in Parliament



This contemporary engraving illustrates Elizabeth I enthroned above the Lords Spiritual, Lords Temporal, and Commons. While the monarch sat at the apex of government, parliamentary consent was constitutionally mandatory to grant extraordinary subsidies (taxation) and pass enforceable statutes.

Hinge Question: Why did Elizabeth jealously protect her "Royal Prerogative" against parliamentary debate, and which specific topics did she strictly forbid MPs from discussing?

SECTION 2 THE VIRGIN QUEEN: LEGITIMACY, GENDER & MARRIAGE

[2.1] Elizabeth's accession was immediately shadowed by existential questions surrounding her **legitimacy**. Under English canon law, only a child born in lawful wedlock could inherit the throne. Devout Catholics throughout Europe and England regarded Elizabeth as illegitimate because they refused to recognize Henry VIII's unilateral divorce from Catherine of Aragon in 1533. The Pope had refused to annul Henry's first marriage, meaning Henry's subsequent marriage to Elizabeth's mother, Anne Boleyn, was viewed in Rome as adulterous. Furthermore, following Anne Boleyn's execution for treason in 1536, Henry VIII himself had pressured Parliament into passing the Second Succession Act, legally bastardizing Elizabeth and excluding her from the succession. Although Henry reinstated her in his 1544 will, Catholics argued that an act of Parliament could never override divine law.

[2.2] Compounding her disputed birth was sixteenth-century European prejudice against female rulers. Christian tradition, rooted in biblical passages from Saint Paul, taught that women were inherently physically and intellectually inferior to men, created to remain under male submission. A **'Queen Regnant'**—a woman ruling in her own right with sovereign executive power—was widely viewed as unnatural, monstrous, and incapable of commanding armies in battle. The traumatic reign of Elizabeth's elder half-sister, Mary I, had reinforced these anxieties: Mary's marriage to Philip of Spain had dragged England into disastrous foreign wars, ignited ferocious domestic rebellions, and subordinated English interests to the Spanish crown.

[2.3] Consequently, the Privy Council and Parliament placed intense, immediate pressure upon Elizabeth to marry and produce a legitimate Protestant heir to secure the Tudor dynasty. Yet marriage presented a lethal constitutional impasse. If Elizabeth married a foreign Catholic prince (such as Philip II of Spain or the Archduke Charles of Austria), England risked becoming a satellite of a foreign empire. Conversely, marrying an English nobleman (such as her

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • KT 1.1

GREAT CHAIN OF BEING

The rigid sixteenth-century social hierarchy established by God, dictating that every person held a fixed, unquestioned rank from monarch down to landless labourer.

ROYAL PATRONAGE

The grant of titles, offices, lands, and trading monopolies by the monarch to secure political loyalty, manage court factions, and maintain nationwide obedience.

PRIVY COUNCIL

A select body of approximately 19 trusted aristocratic advisers who met multiple times weekly to supervise day-to-day administration, finance, and foreign policy.

ROYAL PREROGATIVE

Exclusive sovereign powers belonging solely to the Crown, including the right to decide foreign policy, declare war, and forbid parliamentary debate on religion or succession.

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 VOCABULARY

The Situation on Elizabeth's Accession, 1558

SECTION 3

THE FINANCIAL CRISIS: DEBT, DEBASEMENT & CROWN LANDS

[3.1] Elizabeth inherited a royal treasury on the brink of total collapse. Decades of expensive foreign wars waged by Henry VIII, Edward VI, and Mary I in France and Scotland had emptied the Crown exchequer. In November 1558, the Crown stood **£300,000 in debt**—a staggering liability given that the Crown's ordinary annual income was barely £286,667. Most alarmingly, over £100,000 of this sum was owed to foreign moneylenders on the **Antwerp Exchange**, who demanded crippling interest rates of 14 per cent, leaving England vulnerable to economic blackmail from the Spanish rulers of the Netherlands.

[3.2] The Crown's traditional revenue streams were severely impaired. To finance military campaigns in the 1540s and 1550s, previous monarchs had sold off vast swathes of confiscated monastic lands (Crown lands), permanently reducing royal rental yields. To bridge the deficit, governments had repeatedly resorted to **debasement**—melting down silver coinage and reminting coins with cheap copper alloys. This policy caused catastrophic price inflation: merchant confidence evaporated, domestic food prices skyrocketed, and wages stagnated, sparking intense rural distress. In towns, the essential English cloth export trade to Antwerp fell into deep recession.

[3.3] Elizabeth lacked the financial muscle to maintain a permanent mercenary army or construct modern fortifications without parliamentary grants. Yet calling Parliament to levy extraordinary taxation carried severe political risks: taxes were intensely unpopular among the landed gentry, and MPs routinely demanded royal concessions on religion or marriage in exchange for subsidies. Under Cecil's guidance, Elizabeth adopted rigorous financial austerity. She slashed royal household expenditures by half, sold off non-essential Crown properties (raising £120,000), called in feudal dues, and reformed customs collections. Remarkably, by 1574, through obsessive fiscal caution, Elizabeth cleared the Crown's debts and accumulated a royal surplus.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1520–1598



Sir William Cecil

Principal Secretary of State & Queen's Chief Minister (later 1st Baron Burghley)

Elizabeth's most trusted political confidant, serving as Secretary of State from 1558 to 1572 and Lord High Treasurer from 1572 until his death. He masterminded the 1559 Religious Settlement, stabilized Crown finances, and coordinated state intelligence.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Appointed Principal Secretary on Elizabeth's accession day in November 1558, drafting her initial proclamations and governing directives.
- Steered the contentious Acts of Supremacy and Uniformity through a resistant House of Lords in the spring Parliament of 1559.
- Consistently urged Elizabeth to execute Mary, Queen of Scots, prioritize fiscal prudence, and construct a Protestant alliance against Catholic Spain.

SECTION 4

FOREIGN GEOPOLITICAL THREATS: FRANCE, CALAIS & THE AULD ALLIANCE

[4.1] Beyond her borders, Elizabeth faced an extraordinarily dangerous international landscape. England was surrounded by Catholic superpowers possessing vast military resources. In 1558, England was formally at war with France, having entered the conflict under Mary I as Spain's ally. In January 1558, French forces commanded by the Duke of Guise captured **Calais**, England's last territorial possession on the European mainland, which had been held since 1347. The loss was felt across England as a profound national humiliation: it deprived English merchants of an essential wool-trading port and stripped the navy of a strategic military garrison overlooking the English Channel.

[4.2] In April 1559, Elizabeth signed the **Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis**, bringing the wider European war to an end. Under its terms, France retained Calais for eight years, after which it would be returned to England or France would pay 500,000 crowns—an agreement Elizabeth recognized as a diplomatic smokescreen that permanently ceded the enclave. Even more dangerously, the treaty brought peace between the great Catholic rivals, France and the Holy Roman Empire/Spain. For the first time in sixty years, the two great European superpowers were not at war with each other, raising the terrifying prospect of a united Papal-backed Catholic crusade against Protestant England.

[4.3] This danger was amplified on England's northern frontier by the **Auld Alliance** between France and Scotland. Scotland was ruled by the Catholic regent, Mary of Guise, who governed on behalf of her sixteen-year-old daughter, **Mary, Queen of Scots**. French troops were stationed in Scottish garrisons along the border, placing hostile armies within marching distance of Newcastle and York. Crucially, Mary Stuart was married to Francis, the Dauphin of France. When King Henry II died in 1559 and Francis ascended the throne as Francis II, Mary Stuart became Queen of France and Queen of Scotland simultaneously, while openly declaring herself the legitimate Queen of England. England stood caught in a lethal geopolitical pincer movement.

CORE STRATEGIC MECHANISM

POLITICAL PRAGMATISM • 1558

The Marriage Dilemma: Pros vs. Cons of the Royal Match

In sixteenth-century Europe, marriage was the primary instrument for securing dynastic succession and cementing foreign alliances. Yet for Elizabeth, marriage posed an existential constitutional trap:

- Foreign Prince (e.g. Philip II of Spain, Prince Eric of Sweden):** Would provide military protection and diplomatic weight, but risked dragging England into costly foreign wars and subordinating national interests to a foreign crown (as occurred under Mary I).
- English Nobleman (e.g. Robert Dudley, Earl of Leicester):** Would avert foreign domination, but would inevitably trigger ferocious factional jealousy and aristocratic civil war among rival court families like the Howards and Cecils.
- The Celibate 'Virgin Queen':** Preserved sovereign independence and absolute political control, but left England without a direct Protestant heir, inviting dynastic plots and foreign invasion.

Strategic Legacy: Elizabeth exploited marriage negotiations as diplomatic bait for twenty-five years, stringing along foreign suitors to buy peace while permanently maintaining her sovereign independence.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			KT 1.1 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL:	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION:	
Identify two reasons why the loss of Calais under the Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis (1559) was viewed as a national humiliation.	Explain why Henry VIII's divorce from Catherine of Aragon in 1533 created an ongoing crisis of legitimacy for Elizabeth in 1558.	Evaluate whether Elizabeth's most urgent challenge on accession was financial insolvency or the Franco-Scottish military threat.	

The 'Settlement' of Religion, 1559

Key Enquiry: How successfully did Elizabeth's 1559 'Middle Way' reconcile intense religious divisions while establishing crown authority across England? •
Sections 1 & 2: Context, Governance & Archival Evidence

SECTION 1 RELIGIOUS DIVISIONS & THE SEARCH FOR THE "MIDDLE WAY"

[1.1] In November 1558, England stood on the brink of sectarian civil war. For a quarter of a century, the English people had suffered whiplash religious upheavals: Henry VIII's break with Rome in 1534, Edward VI's radical Calvinist iconoclasm (1547–1553), and Mary I's violent Catholic restoration (1553–1558), during which 284 Protestant men and women were burned alive at the stake as heretics. The realm was geographically and ideologically fractured. The North, the West Midlands, Wales, and Lancashire remained staunchly devoted to traditional Roman Catholicism, Latin masses, and the veneration of saints. Conversely, London, East Anglia, and the South-East contained large, educated, and vocal Protestant populations committed to Reformed theology.

[1.2] Compounding this division was the return of hundreds of **Marian exiles**—hardline English Protestants who had fled Mary's burnings to live in Calvinist Geneva, Zurich, and Strasbourg. Returning home in 1558, these zealous reformers expected Elizabeth to sweep away every trace of popery, abolish the hierarchy of bishops, and establish a pure Presbyterian church modelled on John Calvin's Geneva. Elizabeth herself was an educated Protestant, fluent in Greek and Latin, who revered the English Bible. However, unlike the returning exiles, she was deeply pragmatic: she recognized that imposing a radical Protestant reform on a conservative, Catholic majority would provoke an immediate northern rebellion and invite foreign invasion.

[1.3] Elizabeth's overarching objective was political survival and national stability. She sought to construct a '**Middle Way**' (***Via Media***)—a comprehensive church settlement that was firmly Protestant in its official doctrine and governance, but retained traditional Catholic ceremonial forms, visual liturgy, and episcopal hierarchy. By making the Church inclusive and avoiding aggressive inquisitions into private belief, Elizabeth hoped to secure the outward obedience of moderate Catholics while providing a permanent institutional home for the English Protestant nation.

HISTORICAL SOURCE STATUTE ROLL & TITLE PLATE

April 1559

Source A: The 1559 Act of Supremacy



The opening declaration of the 1559 Elizabethan settlement. By adopting the style "Supreme Governor of this Realm as well in all Spiritual or Ecclesiastical Things" rather than Henry VIII's "Supreme Head", Elizabeth offered deliberate conciliation to Catholic consciences while asserting total crown control over the Church.

Hinge Question: What practical difference in theological perception was achieved by replacing the word "Head" with "Governor", and why was this crucial for securing moderate Catholic acquiescence?

SECTION 2 THE LEGAL PILLARS: ACT OF SUPREMACY & ACT OF UNIFORMITY

[2.1] In the spring Parliament of 1559, Elizabeth and William Cecil steered two landmark statutes through intense legislative opposition in the House of Lords. The first was the **Act of Supremacy (1559)**, which formally severed England's ties to Rome and restored royal control over the Church. In a stroke of brilliant political diplomacy, Elizabeth abandoned Henry VIII's controversial title of 'Supreme Head'. Instead, she assumed the title of '**Supreme Governor**' of the Church of England. This subtle alteration appeased moderate Catholics, who believed that only Jesus Christ or the Pope could be head of the Church, as well as Marian exiles who argued that scripture forbade a woman from claiming spiritual headship.

[2.2] The Act of Supremacy made an **Oath of Supremacy** mandatory for all public officials, judges, MPs, and clergymen, requiring them to swear allegiance to the Queen as Supreme Governor. Any official refusing the oath was stripped of their office and livelihood. Crucially, while all but one of Mary's Catholic bishops refused the oath and were replaced with moderate Protestants, the vast majority of parish priests—roughly 9,000 across England—took the oath and kept their livings, guaranteeing administrative continuity across the countryside. The act also established the Court of High Commission to prosecute religious dissent.

[2.3] The second pillar was the **Act of Uniformity (1559)**, which dictated that every parish in the kingdom must follow an identical pattern of worship. It mandated the universal use of an updated 1559 **Book of Common Prayer**, written in English. To reconcile conservative Catholics, the wording around the communion service was left deliberately ambiguous: the prayer book combined the 1549 Protestant phrasing acknowledging Christ's sacrifice with traditional Catholic formulas referring to Christ's body and blood, allowing worshippers to interpret the Eucharist according to their own conscience. Church attendance on Sundays and Holy Days was made compulsory: those who failed to attend

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • KT 1.2

SUPREME GOVERNOR

The compromise title assumed by Elizabeth in the 1559 Act of Supremacy, appeasing Catholics who believed only Christ or the Pope could be Supreme Head of the Church.

ACT OF UNIFORMITY

The 1559 law establishing a single, compulsory form of national worship, enforcing the Book of Common Prayer and imposing a 1-shilling fine on recusants.

RECUSANT

A devout Catholic who refused to attend Church of England Sunday services, choosing to practice the Roman faith in secret and pay recurring financial penalties.

ROYAL INJUNCTIONS

A set of 57 royal administrative instructions issued in 1559, ordering English Bibles in parishes, banning pilgrimages, and mandating preacher licenses.

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 VOCABULARY

The 'Settlement' of Religion, 1559

SECTION 3THE ROYAL INJUNCTIONS & MECHANISMS OF ENFORCEMENT

[3.1] To enforce the settlement at parish level, William Cecil issued fifty-seven **Royal Injunctions (1559)**. These detailed administrative orders instructed the clergy on how Sunday services must be conducted. The Injunctions struck a careful balance: they commanded priests to teach the Royal Supremacy, denounce the Pope's usurped authority, and ensure that every parish church purchased a large copy of the Bible in English. To eradicate traditional Catholic 'superstition', pilgrimages were outlawed, fake relics were destroyed, and candle-burning before shrines was banned.

[3.2] However, Elizabeth inserted vital ceremonial concessions to reassure conservative parishioners. Church interiors retained an altar table rather than a plain wooden communion board; music and organ-playing were encouraged; kneeling during prayer and bowing at the name of Jesus were enforced; and clergymen were permitted to marry only with the explicit approval of their bishop and two Justices of the Peace. Clergy were required to wear traditional liturgical dress: a white linen surplice during services and an outdoor black cope. Preaching was strictly restricted: to prevent radical puritan or Catholic rabble-rousing, only ministers licensed by the Crown or a bishop were allowed to deliver sermons; unlicensed clergy were required to read approved homilies.

[3.3] Enforcement was carried out through nationwide episcopal **visitations**. In the summer of 1559, teams of royal commissioners toured every diocese in England, inspecting church buildings, examining clergy qualifications, checking for English Bibles, and administering the Oath of Supremacy. Approximately 400 Marian priests who refused to conform were deprived of their posts, but the overwhelming majority took the oath. Visitations were repeated every three to four years, ensuring that parish life steadily conformed to the statutory Elizabethan baseline.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL1504–1575



Matthew Parker
Archbishop of Canterbury (1559–1575)

Appointed Archbishop of Canterbury by Elizabeth in 1559 to implement and defend the 'Middle Way'. A moderate Protestant scholar who had served as Anne Boleyn's chaplain, Parker provided intellectual stability and enforced clerical discipline during the Vestment Controversy.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Consecrated Archbishop in December 1559, supervising the restructuring of the Church of England after the Marian restoration.
- Drafted the Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1563), establishing the theological doctrine of the reformed Church of England.
- Issued the 1566 'Book of Advertisements' enforcing uniform clerical dress, firmly dismissing 37 London Puritan clergy who refused to comply.

SECTION 4THE CHURCH OF ENGLAND AS AN INSTRUMENT OF SOCIAL CONTROL

[4.1] In sixteenth-century England, the Church was far more than a spiritual sanctuary; it was the state's supreme engine for nationwide social control, political indoctrination, and local administration. With no television, radio, or newspapers, the parish pulpit was the Crown's primary communication network. Every Sunday, thousands of congregations assembled to hear royal proclamations read aloud and recite prayers of thanks for the Queen's health and the preservation of the realm. Obedience to the monarch was preached as a direct commandment from God; rebellion was branded as the ultimate mortal sin.

[4.2] The Church operated its own powerful judicial apparatus known as **Church courts (consistory courts)**. These ecclesiastical tribunals held immense jurisdiction over everyday communal life. While royal common law courts dealt with property disputes and felonies, Church courts policed the moral fabric of society: prosecuting adultery, fornication, slander, witchcraft, public drunkenness, and failure to attend church. They also held legal monopolies over civil administrative functions: validating marriages, proving wills, administering probate, and regulating parish charities and schools.

[4.3] Furthermore, the parish church served as the social heartbeat of community life. Churchwardens organized seasonal festivals—such as May Day, harvest suppers, and Easter parish fairs—which reinforced communal solidarity and social cohesion. By preserving the traditional visual splendor of churches, rood screens, and musical liturgy, Elizabeth allowed ordinary peasants to experience the comforting familiarity of their ancestral rituals within a Protestant theological framework. For the first decade of her reign, this pragmatic compromise successfully prevented the catastrophic religious wars that were tearing France apart.

DISCIPLINARY SYNTHESIS

THE VIA MEDIA • 1559

The 1559 Settlement: Strategic Compromise Matrix

Elizabeth's 'Middle Way' was designed to establish national conformity while avoiding religious persecution that could trigger civil war:

PROTESTANT VICTORIES:

- English Book of Common Prayer mandatory in all parishes.
- Monasteries dissolved; Catholic shrines and pilgrimages banned.
- Royal Supremacy restored; papal authority formally abolished.
- Clergy permitted to marry with episcopal permission.

CATHOLIC CONCESSIONS:

- Title changed to 'Supreme Governor' (reassuring Catholic consciences).
- Priests wore traditional Catholic vestments (surplice/cope).
- Communion wording deliberately ambiguous regarding transubstantiation.
- Modest recusancy fine of 1 shilling per missed Sunday service.

Strategic Legacy: The Settlement prioritized political outward obedience over private conscience, successfully securing national order for a decade before foreign papal intervention escalated tensions.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

KT 1.2 SYNTHESIS

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL:
What specific change in royal title was introduced by the 1559 Act of Supremacy, and why was it significant?

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:
Explain why the Church of England served as the Crown's primary instrument of social control in rural parishes.

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION:
Assess how far the 1559 Religious Settlement achieved its goal of creating a broadly accepted national church.

Challenge to the Religious Settlement

Key Enquiry: To what extent did radical Puritan resistance and domestic Catholic dissent threaten the stability of the Elizabethan regime by 1570? • Sections 1 & 2: Context, Governance & Archival Evidence

SECTION 1 THE PURITAN CHALLENGE: CRUCIFIXES, VESTMENTS & PROPHEYSINGS

[1.1] While the 1559 Religious Settlement achieved broad national acceptance, it faced fierce ideological resistance from two unyielding extremes. From within Protestant ranks came the challenge of the **Puritans**—zealous reformers who believed Elizabeth's 'Middle Way' was a cowardly, half-hearted compromise that retained the idolatrous 'dregs of popery'. Puritans adhered to strict Calvinist theology: they believed in double predestination, rejected the authority of bishops, demanded a church governed by elected elders (Presbyterians), and insisted that any practice not explicitly mentioned in the Bible was a sinful invention of the Antichrist.

[1.2] The Puritan challenge manifested in two major flashpoints during the 1560s. The first was the **Crucifix Controversy**. Elizabeth insisted on keeping a silver crucifix and burning candles in her royal chapel, and ordered that every parish church retain a crucifix on the rood screen to comfort Catholic parishioners. Puritan bishops, led by Edmund Grindal and John Jewel, fiercely condemned crucifixes as idolatrous images that violated the Second Commandment. Several bishops threatened to resign en masse. Lacking educated Protestant clergymen to replace them, Elizabeth backed down and removed crucifixes from parish churches, though she stubbornly retained one in her private chapel.

[1.3] The second crisis was the **Vestment Controversy (1565–1566)**. Puritans rejected the mandatory white linen surplice, arguing that special priestly garments suggested ministers possessed supernatural powers to turn bread into Christ's body. By 1565, many London preachers were refusing to wear the surplice, dressing in plain black gowns. Elizabeth ordered Archbishop Matthew Parker to enforce uniform dress. In 1566, Parker issued the *Book of Advertisements* and summoned 110 London ministers to Lambeth Palace for a dress inspection. Thirty-seven ministers boldly refused to conform and were summarily dismissed from their livings. Despite their fury, Puritans remained politically loyal to Elizabeth because the only alternative—a Catholic monarch like Mary Stuart—was unthinkable.

HISTORICAL SOURCE PAPAL DECREE & SEAL

25 February 1570

Source A: The Papal Bull Regnans in Excelsis



The official decree issued by Pope Pius V excommunicating Elizabeth Tudor. The bull declared: "We do out of the fullness of our Apostolic power declare the aforesaid Elizabeth to be a heretic and favourer of heretics... and we also declare her to be deprived of her pretended title to the aforesaid crown."

Hinge Question: Why did Pope Pius V's release of this bull in 1570 inadvertently undermine English Catholics by making religious loyalty synonymous with treason in the eyes of the Crown?

SECTION 2 THE DOMESTIC CATHOLIC CHALLENGE & RECUSANCY

[2.1] The Catholic challenge posed a far graver existential danger. In 1558, a substantial portion of the English population—and perhaps one-third of the nobility—remained devoted to Roman Catholicism. In northern counties such as Yorkshire, Durham, and Lancashire, Catholic influence was entrenched under the protection of ancient feudal families like the Percys (Earls of Northumberland) and the Nevilles (Earls of Westmorland). These magnates maintained private domestic chaplains who celebrated Latin masses in manor house attics, shielded secret priests, and quietly boycotted the local parish church.

[2.2] During the early 1560s, Elizabeth pursued a calculated policy of strategic leniency. She instructed county magistrates and JPs not to enforce recusancy fines with excessive severity, famously remarking that she had "no desire to make windows into men's souls." Elizabeth understood that pushing conservative Catholics into a corner would spark a peasant uprising. Moderate Catholics attended Church of England services to avoid fines and show outward loyalty, while privately practicing traditional devotions at home—a group historians describe as 'church papists'.

[2.3] However, this delicate balance collapsed in the late 1560s. In 1566, Pope Pius V issued an official instruction forbidding English Catholics from attending Church of England services under pain of mortal sin. Simultaneously, the Catholic northern nobility grew intensely alienated: Elizabeth systematically bypassed ancient Catholic peers in favor of Protestant 'new men' like Cecil, while Protestant bishops aggressively cracked down on traditional northern customs. In November 1569, this resentment exploded into the armed **Revolt of the Northern Earls**, proving that domestic Catholicism could easily mobilize into armed rebellion against the Crown.

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • KT 1.3

VESTMENT CONTROVERSY

The 1565–66 dispute where radical Puritan clergy refused to wear Catholic-style surplices and copes, resulting in the sacking of 37 London ministers by Archbishop Parker.

PURITAN

A committed, radical Protestant who believed Elizabeth's 1559 settlement was an incomplete compromise, seeking to completely purify the Church of popish ceremonies and bishops.

COUNTER-REFORMATION

The aggressive global campaign launched by the Catholic Papacy and Council of Trent to stamp out Protestant heresy and reclaim England and Europe for Rome.

PAPAL BULL

An official formal decree with a lead seal issued by the Pope. In 1570, *Regnans in Excelsis* excommunicated Elizabeth and ordered her subjects to rebel.

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 VOCABULARY

Challenge to the Religious Settlement

SECTION 3

THE EUROPEAN COUNTER-REFORMATION & SEMINARY INFILTRATION

[3.1] The domestic Catholic threat was dramatically amplified by international developments. Across Western Europe, the Catholic Church launched the **Counter-Reformation**—a militant, highly coordinated campaign to stamp out Protestant heresy and reclaim lost territories for Rome. Spearheaded by the **Council of Trent (1545–1563)**, the Catholic hierarchy reformed Church abuses, standardized Latin theology, and established aggressive missionary orders like the Society of Jesus (Jesuits) to lead the spiritual reconquest.

[3.2] A central weapon in this campaign was the training of English Catholic priests in continental Europe. In 1568, an exiled English Catholic scholar, **Cardinal William Allen**, founded a specialized seminary college at Douai in the Spanish Netherlands. The college was established to train English Catholic youths in missionary theology and ordain them as seminary priests. From 1574 onwards, these priests were smuggled into England disguised as merchants, soldiers, and tutors. Sheltered in Catholic manor houses in specialized 'priest holes' built by Nicholas Owen, they traveled from village to village celebrating secret Latin masses, hearing confessions, and stiffening Catholic resistance.

[3.3] For the Elizabethan regime, the seminary priests were not mere religious ministers; they were viewed as hostile enemy agents sent by foreign Catholic superpowers. The Spanish Netherlands, lying directly across the English Channel, was garrisoned by 50,000 veteran Spanish troops under the brutal Duke of Alba, who was crushing the Dutch Protestant revolt. English ministers feared that seminary priests were preparing a domestic Catholic fifth column to assist a Spanish invasion fleet, transforming religious faith into a vital front of European geopolitics.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL1504–1572



Pope Pius V
Bishop of Rome & Supreme Pontiff of the Roman Catholic Church (1566–1572)

A fierce inquisitor and leader of the Counter-Reformation who hardened the Catholic Church's stance against Protestant monarchs. In 1570, he issued the fateful Papal Bull **Regnans in Excelsis**, decisively transforming English Catholic dissent into political treason.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Enforced the decrees of the Council of Trent, demanding total Catholic separation from Protestant church services and rituals.
- Issued the Papal Bull **Regnans in Excelsis** on 25 February 1570, declaring Elizabeth a heretic and excommunicating her from the Church.
- Explicitly absolved English Catholics of their oath of allegiance to the Crown, declaring that obeying Elizabeth was a mortal sin.

SECTION 4

THE 1570 PAPAL BULL: REGNANS IN EXCELSIS & THE TREASON THRESHOLD

[4.1] The ultimate turning point in Elizabethan religious history occurred on 25 February 1570, when Pope Pius V issued the fateful Papal Bull **Regnans in Excelsis**. This decree was an act of extraordinary spiritual aggression. The Pope officially excommunicated Elizabeth, castigating her as "the pretended Queen of England and the servant of crime." The bull declared Elizabeth a heretic, stripped her of her royal title, and released all English subjects from their oaths of fealty and obedience. Most dangerously, the Pope commanded English Catholics to disobey the Queen's laws under threat of excommunication.

[4.2] **Regnans in Excelsis** placed English Catholics in an impossible, tragic dilemma. Before 1570, a Catholic could remain a loyal subject of Queen Elizabeth while privately practicing their faith. After 1570, the Pope insisted that total loyalty to Rome required active disobedience to the Crown. Conversely, the Elizabethan government could no longer view recusancy as harmless personal eccentricity: anyone who acknowledged the Pope's authority was now, by definition, affirming that Elizabeth was not the lawful queen and that her deposition was a religious duty.

[4.3] Parliament responded decisively to the Papal Bull with the **Treasons Act (1571)**. This harsh statute made it high treason, punishable by hanging, drawing, and quartering, to declare that Elizabeth was not the lawful queen, to possess or publish papal bulls, or to convert anyone to the Roman Catholic faith. Anyone leaving England for more than six months without royal permission had their lands confiscated. The 1570 bull permanently shattered Elizabeth's policy of calculated leniency, forging an unbreakable link between English Protestantism and patriotic national survival.

CRITICAL TURNING POINTPAPAL DIPLOMACY • 1570

The Mutation of Catholic Dissent: Faith to High Treason
Before 1570, Elizabeth tolerated Catholic recusants who quietly paid their 1-shilling fines, famously refusing to "make windows into men's souls." The 1570 Papal Bull shattered this compromise:

- The Papal Dilemma:** English Catholics were placed in an impossible moral double-bind: obedience to their Queen meant eternal damnation by the Pope, while obedience to the Pope made them traitors liable to horrific execution.
- The Treasons Act (1571):** Parliament responded swiftly by making it high treason to possess or publish papal bulls, describe Elizabeth as a heretic, or attempt to convert English subjects to Rome.
- Geopolitical Justification:** Foreign Catholic monarchs (Philip II of Spain and the French Guise faction) now possessed explicit spiritual sanction to assassinate Elizabeth and invade England.

Strategic Legacy: **Regnans in Excelsis** backfired on English Catholics: instead of rallying the populace to rebellion, it unified patriotic English Protestants and forced the Elizabethan state to criminalize Catholic practice.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT			KT 1.3 SYNTHESIS
1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL:	2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:	3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION:	
State two features of the 1566 Vestment Controversy between Elizabeth and Puritan clergy.	Explain why the 1570 Papal Bull fundamentally altered the legal position of English Catholics.	Evaluate whether the Puritan challenge or the Catholic challenge posed the greater danger to Elizabeth between 1559 and 1569.	

The Problem of Mary, Queen of Scots, 1568–69

Key Enquiry: Why did the dramatic arrival of Mary Stuart in England in 1568 create an insoluble dynastic and security crisis for Elizabeth I? • Sections 1 & 2:
Context, Governance & Archival Evidence

SECTION 1 MARY STUART'S DYNASTIC PEDIGREE & THE SCOTTISH CRISIS (1560–1568)

[1.1] In May 1568, Elizabeth faced the most dangerous crisis of her early reign: the sudden arrival on English soil of her first cousin once removed, **Mary Stuart, Queen of Scots**. Born in 1542, Mary was the granddaughter of Margaret Tudor, Henry VIII's elder sister. To Catholics throughout Europe who rejected Henry's marriage to Anne Boleyn, Mary Stuart held a dynastically superior claim to the English crown than Elizabeth herself. Furthermore, since Elizabeth had no children and refused to name a successor, Mary was the universally acknowledged **heir presumptive**.

[1.2] Mary's personal life was marked by dramatic romance and political catastrophe. Following the death of her French husband, King Francis II, in 1560, Mary returned to Scotland in 1561 to rule a turbulent, divided kingdom dominated by Protestant Scottish lords (the Lords of the Congregation). In 1565, Mary married her English cousin, **Henry Stuart, Lord Darnley**, uniting two powerful claims to the English throne and producing a son, James, in 1566. However, the marriage was disastrous. Darnley was arrogant, violent, and jealous: in March 1566, he led a gang of Scottish nobles who burst into Mary's private chambers at Holyrood Palace and murdered her Italian secretary, David Rizzio, stabbing him fifty-six times in front of the pregnant Queen.

[1.3] Eleven months later, in February 1567, Darnley was murdered in a house at **Kirk o'Field** in Edinburgh. The building was blown apart by gunpowder, but Darnley's body was found strangled in the garden. Scandal turned to outrage when, just three months later, Mary married the chief suspect in Darnley's murder, the ambitious Protestant **James Hepburn, Earl of Bothwell**. Convinced of Mary's complicity, the Scottish Protestant nobility rose in armed rebellion. Mary was imprisoned in the island fortress of **Lochleven Castle** and forced to abdicate her throne on 24 July 1567 in favour of her one-year-old son, who became King James VI.

HISTORICAL SOURCE FORMAL STATE PORTRAIT IN CAPTIVITY c. 1578

Source A: The Sheffield Portrait of Mary Stuart



Painted during Mary's prolonged captivity in England, showing the Scottish queen dressed in sombre black with an ornate rosary and crucifix prominently displayed at her waist. The portrait deliberately projected pious Catholic royalty, dynastic victimhood, and sovereign innocence.

Hinge Question: How did Mary Stuart's continuous display of Catholic piety and royal symbols exacerbate the security paranoia of William Cecil and Francis Walsingham?

SECTION 2 THE ESCAPE, LANGSIDE & THE WORKINGTON LANDING (1568)

[2.1] Mary was not prepared to languish in captivity. In May 1568, with the aid of loyal supporters, she staged a daring midnight escape from Lochleven Castle. Rallying a 6,000-strong royal army, Mary marched to confront the Scottish Regent, her Protestant half-brother, the Earl of Murray. On 13 May 1568, the two armies clashed at the **Battle of Langside** near Glasgow. Mary's forces were routed in less than an hour, leaving her cause in Scotland completely shattered.

[2.2] Fearing recapture and execution, Mary fled south on horseback across wild Scottish moors for three days without rest. Disguised as a common countrywoman, she reached the Solway Firth and made the fateful decision to cross the border into England. On 16 May 1568, in an open fishing boat, Mary landed at **Workington in Cumberland**, penniless and lacking even a change of clothes. She immediately dispatched a passionate letter to Elizabeth, appealing for sisterly protection, royal sanctuary, and an English army to restore her to her Scottish throne.

[2.3] Mary's arrival struck Whitehall like an earthquake. Sir William Cecil recognized immediately that Mary's physical presence on English soil was an unmitigated disaster for national security. The Queen of Scots was beautiful, charismatic, devoutly Catholic, and possessed an unquestioned royal bloodline. In England, she was an anointed monarch who commanded the immediate sympathy of the Catholic northern gentry. Far from being a helpless refugee, Mary Stuart was a living, breathing replacement for Elizabeth Tudor.

HISTORICAL SOURCE CONTESTED PRIMARY Presented December 1568 CORRESPONDENCE

Source B: Facsimile of a Casket Letter



A facsimile excerpt of the infamous letters produced by the Scottish Protestant Regent, the Earl of Murray, at the Conference of York. The letters purported to show Mary conspiring with Bothwell to blow up Kirk o'Field and assassinate her husband, Lord Darnley.

Hinge Question: Why did Elizabeth deliberately issue a verdict of "not proven" regarding the Casket Letters rather than declaring Mary guilty or innocent?

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • KT 1.4

HEIR PRESUMPTIVE

The person dynastically entitled to inherit the crown if the reigning monarch dies without direct legitimate offspring (Mary Stuart held this claim from 1558).

CASKET LETTERS

A collection of eight French love letters and sonnets allegedly written by Mary Stuart to Bothwell, presented as evidence of her complicity in Darnley's murder.

CONFERENCE OF YORK

The 1568–69 judicial enquiry convened by Elizabeth to examine the Scottish charges against Mary Stuart, concluding with an ambiguous verdict of "not proven".

ANointed MONARCH

A ruler consecrated by holy oil in a church coronation, believed to rule by Divine Right, making their trial, deposition, or execution a grave spiritual sin.

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 VOCABULARY

The Problem of Mary, Queen of Scots, 1568–69

SECTION 3 THE CONFERENCE OF YORK & THE CASKET LETTERS (1568–1569)

[3.1] Elizabeth found herself trapped in an acute constitutional impasse. She could not return Mary to Scotland with an army, as that would overthrow the friendly Protestant Scottish regents who secured England's northern border. Nor could she send Mary to France, where Catholic armies would use her to launch an invasion across the Channel. Yet setting Mary free in England was equally impossible, as she would tour Catholic estates and rally rebels to seize the English crown. To resolve the crisis, Elizabeth convened a special judicial commission at the **Conference of York (October 1568 – January 1569)**, ostensibly to investigate the Scottish lords' charges against their queen.

[3.2] The Scottish Regent Murray arrived at York determined to justify Mary's forced deposition. He produced the infamous **Casket Letters**—a silver box containing eight letters and love sonnets in French, allegedly written by Mary to Bothwell, which proved she had lured Darnley to Kirk o'Field to be murdered. Mary vehemently denied writing the letters, claiming they were forgeries produced by Murray's faction. Crucially, Mary refused to enter a formal plea or attend the hearings, arguing that as an anointed sovereign queen, she answered only to God and could not be put on trial by subjects or foreign judges.

[3.3] Elizabeth utilized the Conference of York as a masterclass in diplomatic ambiguity. She had no desire to prove Mary guilty of regicide, as declaring that subjects could lawfully depose an anointed monarch would establish a terrifying precedent that could be turned against Elizabeth herself. However, declaring Mary innocent would force Elizabeth to restore her to Scotland. Consequently, Elizabeth delivered a classic verdict of '**not proven**': she announced that there was insufficient evidence to prove Mary's guilt, but also insufficient evidence to clear her name. This cynical compromise allowed Elizabeth to refuse Mary an audience at court and justify holding her in English captivity indefinitely.

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL

1542–1587

**Mary Stuart (Mary, Queen of Scots)**

Queen of Scotland (1542–1567) & Catholic Claimant to the English Throne

Elizabeth's first cousin once removed, granddaughter of Henry VIII's sister Margaret Tudor, and legitimate Catholic heir presumptive. Her arrival in England in 1568 in an open fishing boat triggered a permanent dynastic and security crisis that plagued Elizabeth for nearly two decades.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Claimed the English crown upon Mary I's death in 1558, quartering the royal arms of England with those of France and Scotland.
- Forced to abdicate the Scottish throne at Lochleven Castle in 1567 following the scandalous murder of Darnley and marriage to Bothwell.
- Escaped to England in May 1568, where she remained in honourable English custody for 19 years until her execution at Fotheringhay in 1587.

SECTION 4 THE IMPRISONMENT OF AN ANOINTED QUEEN & THE GATHERING STORM

[4.1] Following the Conference of York, Mary was transferred into honourable custody under the custody of George Talbot, 6th Earl of Shrewsbury. For the next nineteen years, Mary was moved between remote, damp midland fortresses—including Tutbury Castle, Sheffield Castle, and Wingfield Manor. She was treated as a royal guest: allowed a retinue of thirty Catholic servants, fine French food, horses for exercise, and embroidery materials. Yet behind the gilded bars, she was a closely guarded state prisoner.

[4.2] Captivity failed to neutralize the threat; instead, it concentrated it. Mary Stuart became a permanent living magnet for Catholic conspiracy. English Catholic nobles, humiliated by Cecil's Protestant ascendancy and resentful of the religious settlement, began to look to Mary as their deliverer. Furthermore, foreign ambassadors—most notably Roberto Ridolfi (the Papal agent) and Don Guerau de Spes (the Spanish ambassador)—routinely smuggled secret correspondence to Mary, plotting to marry her to England's premier Catholic nobleman, Thomas Howard, 4th Duke of Norfolk.

[4.3] By the autumn of 1569, Mary's presence catalyzed the very catastrophe Elizabeth had sought to avoid. In November 1569, the Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland raised the banner of Catholic rebellion, marching five thousand armed men into Durham Cathedral to restore the Latin mass before advancing south to liberate Mary from Tutbury Castle. Although royal forces crushed the revolt, the template was set: for the remainder of her life, Mary Stuart remained the focal point of continuous domestic conspiracies, Spanish invasion plans, and papal assassination plots that pushed Elizabethan England inexorably toward war.

CONSTITUTIONAL IMPASSE

DIPLOMATIC CRISIS • 1568

Elizabeth's Four Fatal Options Regarding Mary Stuart

When Mary landed at Workington in May 1568, Elizabeth faced four equally dangerous constitutional choices:

- Option A: Restore Mary to Scotland with an English Army:** Would uphold the divine right of anointed monarchs, but would alienate Scotland's Protestant regents and replace friendly allies with a hostile Catholic regime.
- Option B: Exile Mary to France:** Would remove the immediate problem from England, but would allow Mary to rally French royal forces and organize a Catholic invasion fleet across the Channel.
- Option C: Grant Mary Free Passage in England:** Would enable her to tour the Catholic northern counties, meeting disgruntled nobility and actively rallying support to depose Elizabeth.
- Option D: Keep Mary in Indefinite English Captivity:** Avoided foreign war and immediate rebellion, but turned Mary into a permanent living martyr and figurehead for endless domestic plots.

Strategic Legacy: Elizabeth chose Option D. By keeping Mary captive under the Earl of Shrewsbury, she preserved temporary peace while unwittingly constructing the catalyst for nineteen years of continuous assassination plots.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & DISCIPLINARY ASSESSMENT

KT 1.4 SYNTHESIS

1. KNOWLEDGE RECALL:

State two features of the 1568–69 Conference of York and the investigation into the Casket Letters.

2. CAUSAL ANALYSIS:

Explain why Mary Stuart's arrival in England in May 1568 placed Elizabeth in an impossible diplomatic dilemma.

3. HISTORICAL EVALUATION:

Assess how far the problem of Mary, Queen of Scots destabilized Elizabethan England in the late 1560s.

Key Topic 1 Synoptic Matrix & Causal Chronology

Thematic Synthesis: Analysing how Elizabeth consolidated royal authority across government, religious settlement, and dynastic security.

CORE CRISIS DIMENSION	THE CRISIS IN 1558	ELIZABETH'S STRATEGIC RESPONSE	THE REALITY BY 1569
Royal Legitimacy & Gender	Viewed as illegitimate by Catholic Europe; 16th-century prejudice against female 'Queen Regnant'.	Adopted title 'Supreme Governor'; preserved sovereign independence by remaining unmarried; created cult of Virgin Queen.	Firm royal authority established; marriage negotiations exploited as diplomatic leverage with Spain and France.
Crown Finance & Economy	Crown was £300,000 in debt; £100,000 owed to Antwerp at 14%; debasement causing rampant inflation.	Cut royal household costs by half; sold Crown lands (£120,000); reminted coinage to restore silver value.	Debt reduced substantially; Crown credit restored in Antwerp; royal dependency on Parliament minimized.
Religious Division	Fractured kingdom: conservative Catholic North/West vs radical Protestant South-East and returning Marian exiles.	1559 Settlement ('Middle Way'): Act of Supremacy, Act of Uniformity, ambiguous English Prayer Book, 1s recusancy fine.	Broad outward conformity secured for a decade; Puritan complaints contained; Catholic resistance festering under the surface.
Foreign Military Threat	Calais lost (1558); France allied with Scotland (Auld Alliance); French garrisons stationed on northern border.	Concluded Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis (1559); supported Scottish Protestant lords in 1560 to expel French troops.	French troops expelled from Scotland; northern border stabilized until Mary Stuart's arrival in England in 1568.

MASTER CHRONOLOGY: TURNING POINTS (1558–1570)

CAUSAL PROGRESSION

17 Nov 1558: Accession of Elizabeth I Mary I dies; 25-year-old Elizabeth succeeds; appoints William Cecil Principal Secretary at Hatfield House.	Jan–Apr 1559: The 1559 Settlement Parliament passes the Acts of Supremacy & Uniformity; Royal Injunctions enforce national Protestant baseline.	Apr 1559: Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis Peace between France and Spain; England formally surrenders Calais, ending two centuries of English mainland rule.
Mar 1566: Book of Advertisements Archbishop Parker enforces clerical vestments; 37 London Puritan ministers dismissed, sparking Vestment Controversy.	16 May 1568: Mary Stuart Lands in England Mary escapes Lochleven, flees across Solway Firth in a fishing boat to Workington, Cumberland, seeking English refuge.	Oct 1568 – Jan 1569: Conference of York Judicial inquiry into Darnley's murder and Casket Letters concludes with verdict of "not proven"; Mary held captive.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES • THE SUCCESS OF THE ELIZABETHAN SETTLEMENT

Traditional View (J.E. Neale): Elizabeth was a determined moderate forced into a more radical Protestant settlement than she wished by a vocal, well-organized 'Puritan Choir' in the House of Commons. Her Middle Way was a triumphant personal masterpiece of political moderation.

Revisionist View (Christopher Haigh / Norman Jones): The primary obstacle was not Puritans in the Commons, but conservative Catholic bishops and peers in the House of Lords. The 1559 settlement did not create permanent religious peace; it alienated devout Catholics and Puritans alike, postponing inevitable conflict until foreign intervention in 1570.

Edexcel Paper 2: Examination Strategy & Model Answers

Examination Blueprint: Deconstructing Question 1 (Features [4m]), Question 2 (Causation [12m]), and Question 3 (Evaluative Essay [16m]).

QUESTION 1: DESCRIBE TWO FEATURES OF... [4 MARKS • 5 MINUTES]

TARGET: 2 DISTINCT POINTS + SUPPORTING DETAIL

Exam Prompt: Describe two features of the 1559 Act of Uniformity. [4 marks]

Feature 1: One feature was the introduction of a compulsory English Book of Common Prayer that had to be used in all churches across England. [1 mark]
This prayer book contained deliberately ambiguous communion wording so that both moderate Catholics and Protestants could participate without violating their conscience. [1 mark]

Feature 2: A second feature was the imposition of financial penalties for non-attendance at church services. [1 mark] Anyone who refused to attend church on Sundays (known as a recusant) was subject to a mandatory fine of one shilling, which was enforced by local churchwardens. [1 mark]

QUESTION 2: EXPLAIN WHY... [12 MARKS • 18 MINUTES]

TARGET: 3 PEEL PARAGRAPHS + SPECIFIC CAUSAL LINKS

Exam Prompt: Explain why Elizabeth I faced threats on her accession to the throne in 1558. You may use: (1) Crown debt, (2) Gender and marriage. [12 marks]

PEEL Structure:

- **Point 1 (Financial Weakness):** Elizabeth inherited an impoverished realm with over £300,000 in Crown debt and annual revenues of only £286,667, with £100,000 owed to Antwerp moneylenders at 14% interest. *Consequence:* Elizabeth lacked the financial reserves to fund a standing army, leaving England defenceless without risky parliamentary taxation.
- **Point 2 (Gender Prejudices & Marriage Trap):** Sixteenth-century patriarchal tradition dictated that women were incapable of leading armies or governing. *Consequence:* Elizabeth faced intense pressure to marry; however, marrying a foreign prince risked foreign domination, while marrying an English noble would spark aristocratic civil war.
- **Point 3 (Geopolitical Threat & Auld Alliance):** The loss of Calais in 1558 humiliated England, while French garrisons in Scotland under Mary of Guise flanked England's northern border. *Consequence:* Mary, Queen of Scots held a strong Catholic claim to the English throne, creating a direct invasion threat.

QUESTION 3: EVALUATIVE ESSAY [16 MARKS + 4 SPAG • 25 MINUTES] TARGET: BALANCED CRITERIA + SUSTAINED HISTORICAL JUDGEMENT

Exam Prompt: "The Catholic challenge was the most serious problem facing Elizabeth between 1558 and 1569." How far do you agree?

Agreed (Catholic Threat Was Greatest):

- Mary Stuart's 1568 arrival provided a living, legitimate Catholic figurehead.
- Northern Earls commanded feudal loyalty and launched armed rebellion in 1569.
- Catholic threat carried foreign backing (France, Spain, Papacy).

Counter-Argument (Other Problems Were Greater):

- £300,000 Crown debt meant Elizabeth could not defend the realm in 1558.
- Puritan challenge divided Protestant leadership (Crucifix & Vestment disputes).
- **Sustained Judgement:** Financial weakness was the root problem; it constrained her ability to combat Catholic challenges.

KEY TOPIC 1 CORE TERMINOLOGY GLOSSARY

12 ESSENTIAL TERMS

GREAT CHAIN OF BEING

Rigid sixteenth-century divine hierarchy placing the monarch at the head of all social ranks down to landless labourers.

PRIVY COUNCIL

Nineteen trusted aristocratic advisers meeting weekly to govern finance, military defense, and administrative law.

ROYAL PREROGATIVE

Exclusive crown powers: deciding foreign policy, marriage, and declaring war without parliamentary debate.

SUPREME GOVERNOR

Elizabeth's title under the 1559 Act of Supremacy, pacifying Catholic consciences while asserting royal control.

ACT OF UNIFORMITY

1559 statute enforcing the English Book of Common Prayer and a 1s fine on recusants who missed Sunday church.

ROYAL INJUNCTIONS

57 administrative rules in 1559: ordering English Bibles, licensing preachers, and banning pilgrimages and shrines.

EPISCOPAL VISITATIONS

Inspections of 9,000 parishes every 3-4 years by commissioners, removing 400 Marian priests who refused the oath.

CHURCH COURTS

Ecclesiastical tribunals policing social morality, slander, marriage, wills, and enforcing church attendance.

CRUCIFIX CONTROVERSY

Puritan bishop campaign against crucifixes in churches, forcing Elizabeth to compromise in parish buildings.

VESTMENT CONTROVERSY

1566 clash over clerical dress: Archbishop Parker's Book of Advertisements dismissed 37 London Puritan ministers.

REGNANS IN EXCELSIS

1570 Papal Bull by Pope Pius V excommunicating Elizabeth, absolving subjects of loyalty and triggering treason laws.

CASKET LETTERS

Eight letters presented at the 1568 Conference of York, allegedly proving Mary Stuart's complicity in Darnley's murder.

KEY TOPIC 1 DIGITAL INTERACTIVE QUIZ & FLASHCARD HUBS

SCAN WITH PHONE CAMERA

KT 1.1

Accession & Government (1558)



INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ

KT 1.2

The Religious Settlement (1559)



INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ

KT 1.3

Puritan & Catholic Challenges



INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ

KT 1.4

Mary, Queen of Scots (1568–69)



INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ

PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY • PAPER 2 PERIOD STUDY SPECIFICATION CHECKLIST

- **1.1 Accession:** Society, government, gender, legitimacy, marriage, Crown debts, debasement, Calais, France & Scotland.
- **1.2 Settlement:** Divisions in 1558, Acts of Supremacy & Uniformity, Prayer Book, Injunctions, Church courts, visitations.
- **1.3 Challenges:** Puritan challenges (crucifix/vestments), Catholic challenge (nobility/papacy), Council of Trent, 1570 Bull.
- **1.4 Mary Stuart:** Dynastic claim, Scottish rebellion, flight to England (1568), Casket Letters, Conference of York, captivity.